

ENVIRONMENTAL ETHICS AND POLITICS★

Environmental ethics is an established field of practical philosophy which reconstructs the essential types of argumentation that can be made for protecting natural entities and use of natural resources. The main principles of environmental ethics are anthropocentrism, physiocentrism (called ecocentrism) and theocentrism.

Environmental ethics includes environmental law, environmental-sociology, ecotheology, ecological economics, ecology and environmental geography. There are many ethical decisions that human beings make with respect to the environment. For example:

- Should humans continue to clear cut forests for the sake of human consumption?
- Why should humans continue to propagate its species, and life itself?
- Should humans continue to make gasoline-powered vehicles?
- What environmental obligations do humans need to keep for future generations?^{[3][4]}
- Is it right for humans to knowingly cause the extinction of a species for the convenience of humanity?
- How should humans best use and conserve the space environment to secure and expand life?
- What role can Planetary Boundaries play in reshaping the human-earth relationship?

Marshall's categories of ethics

According to Marshall, three general ethical approaches have emerged over the last 40 years: Libertarian Extension, Ecologic Extension and Conservation Ethics.

(a) Libertarian extension

Marshall's Libertarian extension is about a civil liberty approach. It is a commitment to extend equal rights to all members of a community. In environmentalism, the community consists of non-humans as well as humans.

1. **Andrew Brennan** was an advocate of ecologic humanism (eco-humanism), the argument that all ontological entities can be given ethical worth purely on the basis that they exist. The work of Arne Naess and his collaborator Sessions also falls under the libertarian extension. But they preferred the term **deep ecology.** Deep ecology is the argument for the intrinsic value or inherent worth of the environment.
2. **Peter Singer's work** on Marshall's libertarian extension. He includes the rights of non-human animals.

(b) Ecologic extension

Alan Marshall's category of ecologic extension places emphasis not on human rights but on the recognition of the fundamental interdependence of all biological entities and their essential diversity. Libertarian Extension is flowing from a political reflection of the natural-world. But ecologic extension is a scientific reflection of the natural world. Ecological Extension is roughly the same classification of Smith's eco-holism. It argues for collective ecological entities like ecosystems or the global environment as a whole entity. **Holmes Rolston** has taken this approach.

(c) Conservation ethics

Marshall's category of conservation ethics is an extension of use-value into the non-human biological world. It focuses only on the worth of the environment in terms of its utility or usefulness to humans. It contrasts the intrinsic value ideas of 'deep ecology', is taken as 'shallow ecology'. It generally argues for the preservation of the environment on the basis that it has extrinsic value – for the welfare of human beings. Therefore, conservation is its pure goal.

Anthropomorphism

The application of human characteristics to anything not human is called **anthropomorphism**. The human feelings cannot be assigned to animal behavior. These animals (especially invertebrate) do not give accurate human behaviour. For example an earthworm is placed on a fishhook. It can be explained in two ways:

- (a) **Anthropomorphic explanation:** We think that the fish can hurt the earthworm. Or it can cause pain in it? Hurt and pain are human feelings. These are present in our conscious. Thus application of hurt and pain to earthworm is anthropomorphism.
- (b) **Physiological explanation:** We can explain this problem in another way. It reduces the anthropomorphic interpretation. We explain it that when the earthworm is placed on the hook, certain receptors are stimulated.

These receptors generate nerve impulses. This impulse travel through neuron and causes reflex action. The impulses stimulate muscles. The contraction of muscles allows the worm to escape from the hook. This explanation gives the actual mechanism of reflex. It does not give the feelings of earthworm.

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